

Left (top to bottom) Carving a spit-roasted *döner kebab* in Istanbul; Greek lamb koftas served with mint yogurt; restaurant-sized souvlaki cooked outdoors in Greece

Below (top to bottom) India's *kakori* kebabs are spicy minced lamb or goat rolls, grilled on skewers; the classic shish kebabs take their name from the Turkish word for "skewer"



Khyber expensive

145 Mahatma Gandhi Road, Fort, Mumbai;
www.khyberrestaurant.com

Counted among Mumbai's top tables, the Khyber specializes in the meat-dominated Punjabi cuisine, including expertly flavored and cooked kebabs and *köfte*. With its reputation for fine dining, impeccable service, and hip decor, the Khyber boasts a fervent following among local celebrities, diplomats, and the business community.

PAKISTAN

In contrast to India, Pakistan's cuisine is firmly rooted in the carnivore camp, and kebabs feature frequently on menus, including *seekh* or *tikka* kebabs (shish kebabs), *shawarma* (doner kebab), and a few Pakistani variations such as *chapli* kebabs – spicy, minced mutton or beef patties shaped like a slipper (*chapli*) served with yogurt, rice, salad, and naan bread.

Gowal Mandi inexpensive

Off Railway Road, Lahore

The network of lanes just south of Railway Road in Lahore is known locally as "Food Street" for its rows of stands selling simple, fresh, and skillfully cooked Pakistani fare. At sunset, the roads close and all the locals congregate. It's a great place to try Pakistani dishes at rock-bottom prices in a great atmosphere.

Village Garden Restaurant moderate

Palace Cinema Bldg., Karachi; +92 21 521 2880

Karachi's oldest surviving restaurant also boasts one

of the capital's best locations: an attractive and breezy garden filled with birdsong and shade where you can watch your *seekh* kebabs spit, sizzle, and emit tantalizing smells on the large outdoor grills.

GREECE

Some claim that the kebab originated in Greece in ancient times, alleging that writers such as Homer, Aristophanes, and Aristotle made reference to it in their works. The Greek *gyros* is akin to the Turkish *döner kebab*, although pork is often used, and *souvlaki* is akin to shish kebabs. They are as universally popular as their Turkish counterparts.

To Etsi inexpensive

Nikoforos Fokas 2, near the White Tower, Thessaloniki; +30 2310 222 469

Simple, basic, and garishly decorated, the To Etsi in Thessaloniki has won a cult following locally for its succulent *souvlaki* stuffed into freshly baked pita bread, served with crunchy salad and generous dollops of homemade hot, spicy, or garlicky sauces.

Varoulko expensive

Pireos 80, Gazi, Athens; www.varoulko.gr

As famous for its startling views of the Acropolis as for the startling modern-Greek creations of the country's only Michelin-star-rated chef, Lefteris Lazarou, the Varoulko is a must for the foodie. Seafood is the specialty, but the meat dishes don't disappoint. Book a rooftop table.



On the Menu in Turkey

There are dozens of varieties of kebab in Turkey. Many are local adaptations named after the place of origin or their founder.

Adana kebab Minced lamb spiced with chili peppers, garlic, parsley, paprika, pepper, and sumac, molded into a sausage and grilled over coals on a special long, flat skewer. The meat is served on top of warm strips of pita bread with a salad of tomatoes, peppers, and sliced onions tossed in sumac.

Buğu kebab Meat is steamed in a sealed terra-cotta pot along with pearl onions, garlic, thyme, sumac, and cumin.

Çiğ kebab Raw, ground lamb pounded with bulgur wheat and onions, spiced with cinnamon, cloves, paprika, and pepper.

Döner kebab Compressed meat (chicken or lamb) grilled on an upright and rotating skewer and sliced onto pita bread.

Erciyes kebab Lamb served on a bed of thinly sliced sautéed potatoes with garlic and yogurt.

Fıstıklı kebab Suckling lamb minced and mixed with herbs and pistachios.

İskender (Bursa) kebab Lamb *döner* layered on a bed of pita bread, topped with tomato sauce and tangy yogurt, then drizzled with lightly browned butter.

Patlıcan kebab Minced or cubed lamb grilled on skewers with eggplant.

Şiş kebab Cubed lamb or chicken marinated in oil, garlic, onion, and black pepper grilled on a skewer with onions and peppers.

Tavuk şiş kebab Chicken cubes marinated in olive oil, thyme, or rosemary,

crushed garlic, black pepper, grated onion, and yogurt, grilled on a skewer over coals.

Testi kebab Lamb or chicken with vegetables (often onion and mushroom), slow-cooked in a sealed terra-cotta pot that is broken open at the dining table.

Tokat kebab Cubed lamb grilled on a skewer along with potato, eggplant, tomato, and garlic.

Urfa kebab Minced lamb, mildly spiced with chili pepper, garlic, paprika, pepper, and sumac, shaped like a sausage and grilled over coals; served with onion salad.

Yoğurtlu şiş kebab Grilled skewers of cubed lamb marinated in oil, garlic, and onion, along with grilled, skewered ground lamb *köfte*, served on a bed of butter-fried pita bread, sprinkled with sumac, salt, and thyme, and topped with fresh tomato sauce, yogurt, and fried strips of eggplant.